The 16th Degree – Prince of Jerusalem



The apron is of crimson, lined and edged with the color saffron. On the flap is an equal balance, held by a hand of justice. In the middle of the apron is a representation of the Second Temple, on one side of which is a sword lying across a buckler, and on the other, a square and a triangle. On the left and right sides are the Phoenician letters equivalent to the Greek letters Alpha and Theta. The colors, crimson bordered with that of the dawn (saffron), are symbolic of faith in the justice and beneficence of God, and of the dawn of hope for the persecuted, proscribed and oppressed. The equal balance, held by the hand of justice, is a symbol of righteousness and impartiality in judgment and of that equilibrium which the Deity maintains throughout the universe. The square and triangle are the appropriate emblems of your Masonic character. Masons, in this and higher degrees, wear the apron in order that they may never forget that they

attained their high rank and dignity by means of Masonic labor; and that, remembering their first estate, they may be courteous and kind, as well as just, to the brethren of the lower degrees.

The cordon is a watered saffron–colored ribbon, four inches broad, bordered with gold. It is worn from the right shoulder to the left hip. On it are embroidered a balance, a hand of justice holding a sword, a poniard, five stars, and two small crowns. At the end hangs a small silver trowel. The cordon of this degree symbolizes, by its colors, the dawn and light. Many symbols are embroidered on the cordon. The balance is a symbol of judicial impartiality. The hand holding the sword of justice is an emblem of that stern severity which is sometimes necessary to repress crime. The poniard or dagger represents that with which Ehud slew the oppressor Eglon, King of Moab (See Judges 3:15–28). The five stars represent the first five Princes of Jerusalem. The two crowns, promised by the Prophet to Zerubbabel and Jeshua, are symbols of civil and religious authorities. The trowel is a symbol of the Mason–builders of the Temple.

The jewel is a medal of gold. On one side is engraved a hand, holding an equal balance, symbolizing the justice and mercy of God, held in equipoise by His single will and infinite wisdom. On the other is a double–edged, cross–hilted sword, with one star over the point and two on each side. The sword stands upright, hilt downward. On one side of the stars is the letter “D,” and on the other, the letter “Z,” the initials of Darius and Zerubbabel. Some versions have the Hebrew letters dalet (ד) and zayin (ז), which are initals of the same names.

DUTIES

To direct and aid those who labor to build the Symbolic Temple.
Judge equitably and fairly.
Provide aid of whatever kind to fellow Princes of Jerusalem.
Keep faith in the justice and beneficence of God.
Press forward with hope for the persecuted and oppressed.

LESSONS

Build Temples of the Living God in our Hearts by following Masonic Truth—justice, equity, morality, wisdom, labor, fidelity, brotherhood—to achieve immortality.

FOR REFLECTION

Will you leave a noble heritage to those who follow you in this world?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

The color saffron, the Seal of Solomon, the colors white, blue, red and violet, five steps to the throne, the scales or balance.

The drama enacted continues the legend of the building of the Second Temple and the walls of the city of Jerusalem. The exiles, who returned to Jerusalem under the protection of Cyrus (537 B.C.), were thwarted in their efforts to rebuild the Temple by the Samaritans and other adversaries, who accused them of intrigue and sedition against the Persian government. Cyrus, occupied with his eastern wars, did not give the Jews the necessary support to continue the work. His successor Cambyses (also known as Artaxerxes, following the references in the Book of Ezra in the Bible), had little sympathy with his struggling subjects. As a result, the restoration of the sanctuary was delayed for seventeen years (Ezra 4:24). The ascent of Darius to the Persian throne gave new hope to the leaders of the Jews. In 520 B.C. the prophets Haggai and Zechariah stirred up the people to renewed efforts. Under their inspiration Zerubbabel, the civil leader of the colony, set earnestly to work (Ezra 5:1–2). An inquiry to Darius by Tattenai, the satrap, or governor, of Syria (Ezra 5:3–17), resulted in the confirmation of the contention that the Jews" proceedings were not only lawful, but actually carried on under royal authority. Darius gave orders that search should be made. In the city of Ecbatana the edict of Cyrus was found containing all that the Jews had claimed (Ezra 6:1–5). Darius, therefore, made a new proclamation insisting that no obstacle should be put in the way of the people of Jerusalem, that the building of the Temple should be forwarded, that interference with the work should be a capital offense and that contributions should be made in money and goods from the king's local revenues for the

expenses of the restoration (Ezra 6:6–12). Accordingly the satrap and his officers carried out the orders of Darius (Ezra 6:13, sq.) with all diligence. As a result, the Temple was finished and dedicated in 516 B. C., the sixth year of the reign of Darius (Barnes's Bible Encyclopedia, 1903, Vol. I, p. 247).

Such is the simple history of the events portrayed in this degree; but this outline hardly conveys the frustrations of the people during the dark days of their persecution or their joy at being able to finish such a noble work.

CEREMONY

To those Scottish Rite Masons who are also York Rite Masons, the colored hangings in the first apartment of this degree—white, blue, red and violet—should be familiar. They are found in the writings of Josephus (*Antiquities* iii.7.7) who derived his description from the Bible where it is said that Solomon "made the veil of blue, purple and crimson and fine linen [white]..." (2 Chronicles 3:14). White symbolizes purity of life and rectitude of conduct. Blue conveys the meaning of universal friendship, benevolence and fidelity. Red signifies zeal and fervency and war. In this instance, purple assumes its ancient meaning of constancy in battle because the colors which comprise purple, blue and red, denote fidelity and war, respectively. Here the four color hangings divide the eastern portion of the apartment from the rest. Behind the hangings is a representation of the Holy of Holies.

The other hangings and the predominant color of the set are saffron, a deep, rich yellow orange, a symbol of the dawn. This apartment represents the Court of Zerubbabel. A passage between this and the second apartment with painted scenes of the countryside represents the country between Jerusalem and Babylon. The second apartment is the Council Chamber of the King of Persia. The predominant colors here are green, white and blue. A Blazing Sun is located over the King's throne.

The candidate represents Kadmiel ben Zabud who offers to assist in the work. Arial explains the work moves painfully and slowly because of the constant interruptions by the Samaritan adversaries. The workmen have become weary

and discouraged; they are compelled to labor with a sword in one hand and a trowel in the other. Another obstacle presents itself; the Syrians have formally questioned the authority of the Jews to rebuild the Temple by transmitting a letter to King Darius of Persia, the successor of Artaxerxes (called Cambyses by Herodotus) who ceased the work on the Temple.

Zerubbabel is chosen, by divine command relayed through Haggai the Prophet, to present the truth to King Darius in Babylon. The journey and admittance to the palace of Darius is met with numerous obstacles which are overcome by the group with the aid of their swords and their faith and trust in the Lord. The King orders the archives be searched for the decree issued by Cyrus which allowed and supported the building of the Temple. Kadmiel is remembered by the Princes as a man and an initiate who treated the people he had overpowered with mercy and generosity.

Upon their return to Jerusalem, Zerubbabel, Kadmiel and the others are received with great celebration, for the end of the great sorrow of Israel is approaching. Jerusalem was no longer the City of Peace (the literal meaning of “Jerusalem”) for the people argued, sold their children into bondage, borrowed money at high interest to buy food and no tribunal existed to judge equitably between men. Zerubbabel appoints judges to decide the controversies between men according to the timeless rules of equity and to the laws of God, with mercy and compassion.

The drama ends as the candidate is received a Prince of Jerusalem and obligated to the work of rebuilding the Holy House of the Temple and the walls of the City of Peace. The duties of a Prince of Jerusalem are: to judge equitably and fairly, to act the peacemaker between brothers, to provide aid of whatever kind to fellow Princes of Jerusalem, to keep faith in the justice and beneficence of God and to press forward with hope for the persecuted and oppressed.

The instruction on the history of the degree begins with events following those portrayed. It includes the completion of the Second Temple (340 B.C.), the conquest of Jerusalem by Ptolemy (320 B.C.), the Maccabees (166 B.C.), the Romans (63 B.C.), the destruction of the Temple by Titus (70 A.D.) and the

rebellion of the Jewish people against Rome in 135 A.D. which resulted in their banishment from Judea, an event now known as the Diaspora, or “Dispersion.” A tradition explains that a few initiates survived and preserved the Ancient Mysteries and instruction for later ages. This long history provides hints of future degrees and clearly shows that the Temple of Solomon is but a symbol. The trials of the Hebrew people– the result of the destruction of the Temple of Liberty occurred because the people lost the True Word, not a word but a concept, and ceased to revere the true God. The characters and drama teach us that the Soldiers of Truth, armed with the sword of courage and the trowel of untiring labor, can propagate Scottish Rite Masonry as a universal philosophy, a moral and political creed, intent upon making good men better men and thus a good world a better world.

LECTURE

A Prince of Jerusalem is no longer expected to rebuild the Temple at Jerusalem. In *Morals and Dogma,* Pike asserts “the whole world is God’s Temple, as is every upright heart.” The pursuit of Masonry is to build the Symbolic Temple all over the world. The special tools of a Prince of Jerusalem are justice and equity; but we are not to forget those tools which we have learned in previous degrees. To follow the path of Masonic Truth is to understand that the action of life is the arena for spiritual and moral improvement because all of life and the world is spiritual and moral.

Justice and Equity:

The Princes of Jerusalem no longer sit as magistrates to judge between the people .... Justice and Equity are still their characteristics. To reconcile disputes and heal dissensions, to restore amity and peace, to soothe dislikes and soften prejudices, are their peculiar duties; and they know that the peacemakers are blessed (p. 241).

Moral and Spiritual in the World:

Remember always that all Masonry is work, and that the trowel is an emblem of

the Degrees in this Council. Labor, when rightly understood, is both noble and ennobling, and intended to develop man's moral and spiritual nature, and not to be deemed a disgrace or a misfortune (p. 242).

[Masonry] *teaches its toiling children that the scene of their daily life is all spiritual, that the very implements of their toil, the fabrics they weave, the merchandise they barter, are designed for spiritual ends; that so believing, their daily lot may be to them a sphere for the noblest improvement* (p. 243).